INDIA@PARIS 2024

A RING OF DETERMINATION

NIKHAT ZAREEN, 28

Sport: *BOXING* 50 kg

Achievements: Two-time World champion, Istanbul 2022 and New Delhi 2023; Gold at Birmingham Commonwealth Games, 2022

How she qualified: Won an Olympic quota after reaching the semis and clinching a bronze at Asian Games, Hangzhou

Soon after the Tokyo Games, Mohammad Jameel Ahmed presented his daughter Nikhat Zareen a silver ring with five Olympic rings, a reminder of her next goal—a medal in Paris. Ahmed's WhatsApp profile photo features a smiling Nikhat pumping her fist wearing that special gift. It was Ahmed, a national-level football player himself, who had decided to direct the energy of his '*shararti* (naughty)' third child into sport and took her to the Collector Ground in Nizamabad, Telangana. Left to herself, the young Nikhat skirted the basketball court and track and was soon absorbed with the happenings in the boxing gym. The rest, of course, is legend.

Paris had been on Nikhat's mind ever since she missed out on a ticket to Tokyo, losing to Mary C. Kom in a heated 2019 trial that was held at her behest, which she insists was about "fair play". "Every day I'd cry. But the people in my life—seniors, sponsors, friends and family—never let me down and kept me motivated," Nikhat told INDIA TODAY late last year. "Hunger *badhta gaya* (my hunger grew) thinking about the goal." Expectations are high for India's female-heavy boxing contingent, with many experts considering Nikhat as a solid bet to add to our medal tally. "*Kabhi socha nahi tha ek ladki* who was once a challenger would become the face of Indian boxing... I feel blessed and grateful," she said during a media interaction weeks before the Games.

Such are the expectations from Nikhat that the bronze she won at the Asian Games last year was seen as an "underperformance". "Even I wasn't satisfied with the bronze," she says. "I took it as a lesson—worked on my mistakes to come back stronger." After a break, she resumed training at the national camp in Patiala. At the Strandja Memorial tournament, she bagged a silver, following it up with a gold in the Elorda Cup in Astana in May, showcasing the steel that has made her a fiery contender.

She will need all of it in Paris. There are nerves, she admits, for it is her first Games, but it's also a source to get her to focus and perform. In a surprising move by the Paris Games boxing unit, Zareen isn't seeded, making her quest for gold one filled with tough fights. But it didn't stop her from winning a world championship last year, and it won't faze her in Paris. "Whenever I get a tough draw, I perform better," she says. "There's no scope for an easy draw at the Olympics. I have to give 100 per cent in every bout." It's what Ahmed wants too. Father to four daughters, he's heard his share of taunts. Today, the Zareen girls are flying high—one's a neurologist, another an orthopaedic, and the youngest a badminton player. "Now we are known as the Zareen family," says Ahmed proudly. ■

–Suhani Singh

"I WASN'T HAPPY WITH THE ASIAN GAMES BRONZE. I RESOLVED TO TAKE IT AS A LESSON, WORK ON MY MISTAKES AND COME BACK STRONGER"

— NIKHAT ZAREEN

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH;** *Hair and make-up:* **SUNIL MADHUKAR SAWANT**